

TRANSPORT, RECONNAISSANCE, AND LIAISON AIRCRAFT

The first military transport aircraft were commercial aeroplanes developed during the interwar period, but purpose-built designs better suited to military operations soon began to appear. Specialist reconnaissance aircraft were developed, too: some, especially those designed to undertake maritime operations, doubled up in the attack role, while others dispensed with armament completely in the interest of being able to fly higher and faster than any armed interceptor the enemy could send against them – a principle that has held into the modern era. Light aircraft were also pressed into military service to operate both in and away from the combat zone.



High-mounted wing gave a good field of view

▲ CONSOLIDATED PBY CATALINA

Launched 1936 **Origin** US

Wingspan 31.7m (104ft)

Length 19.5m (64ft)

Top speed 315kph (196mph)

Engine Two 895kW (1,200hp) Pratt & Whitney R-1830-92 Twin Wasp radials

Designed as a “patrol bomber”, the Catalina is the most successful flying boat ever produced; many are still in use, chiefly to fight wildfires, 75 years after it was introduced.

▲ JUNKERS JU. 52/3M

Launched 1932 **Origin** Germany

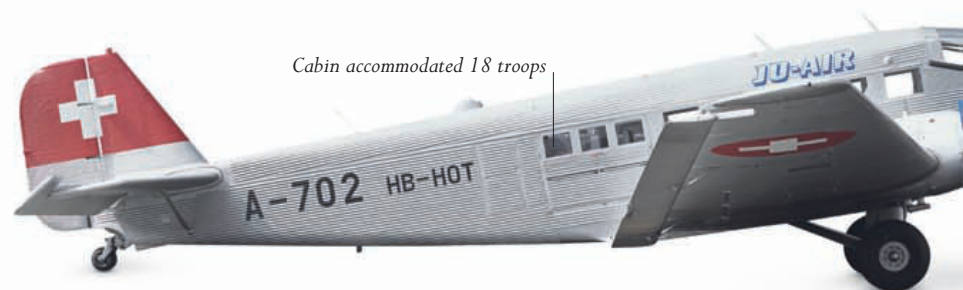
Wingspan 29.25m (95¾ft)

Length 18.9m (62ft)

Top speed 265kph (165mph)

Engine Three 533kW (715hp) BMW 132 radials

With its three motors, rectangular fuselage and corrugated Duralumin skin, the Ju. 52 was instantly recognizable. Originally produced as a 17-seater airliner, it was taken up for military service in 1935. In combat zones, losses were invariably high; 280 were lost in May 1940 during the invasion of the Netherlands.



Cabin accommodated 18 troops



Loop antenna for finding direction

▲ FOCKE-WULF FW. 200 CONDOR

Launched 1937 **Origin** Germany

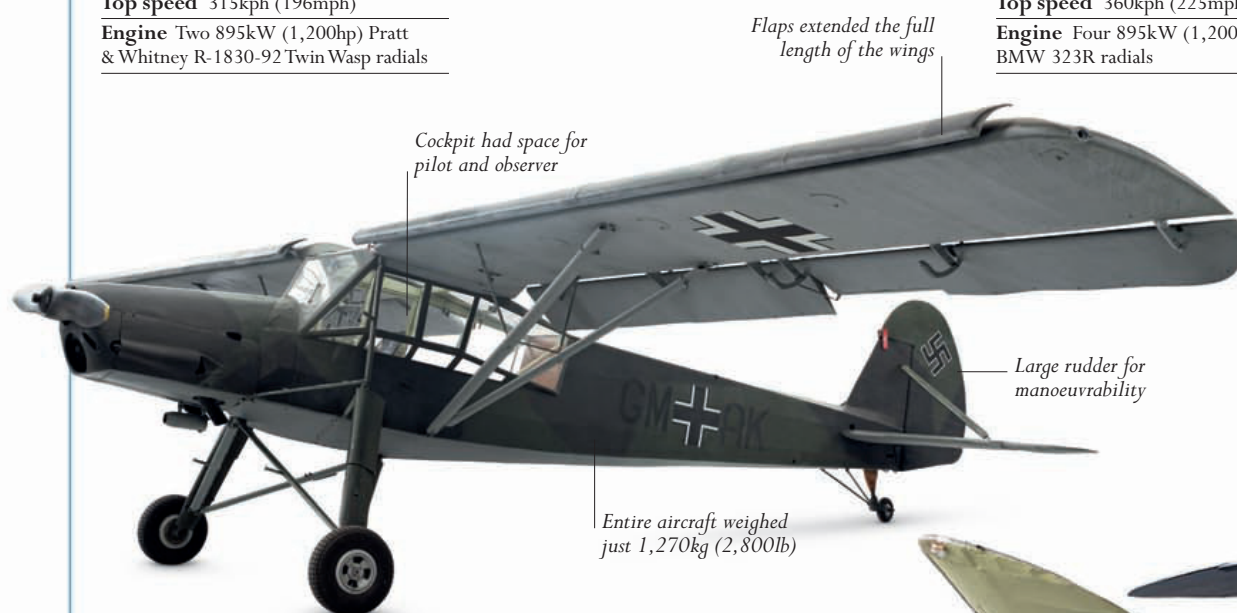
Wingspan 32.85m (107¾ft)

Length 23.45m (77ft)

Top speed 360kph (225mph)

Engine Four 895kW (1,200hp) BMW 323R radials

The Condor was built for Lufthansa as a long-range airliner, but was adapted for military service in mid-1939. It was not robust enough to be a success as a military transport craft, but was better suited to maritime reconnaissance and for attacking shipping. A total of 276 were built, most of which were lost during the war.



Cockpit had space for pilot and observer

Flaps extended the full length of the wings

Large rudder for manoeuvrability

Entire aircraft weighed just 1,270kg (2,800lb)

▲ FIESELER FI.156 STORCH

Launched 1937 **Origin** Germany

Wingspan 14.3m (46¾ft)

Length 9.9m (32½ft)

Top speed 175kph (110mph)

Engine 177kW (240hp) Argus As 10 V8

The Storch (Stork) was designed as an army liaison aircraft. Unusually for a land-based aircraft, it had wings that could be folded back along its fuselage. Its approach speed was so low that in a headwind it appeared to land almost vertically.

► WESTLAND LYSANDER

Launched 1938 **Origin** UK

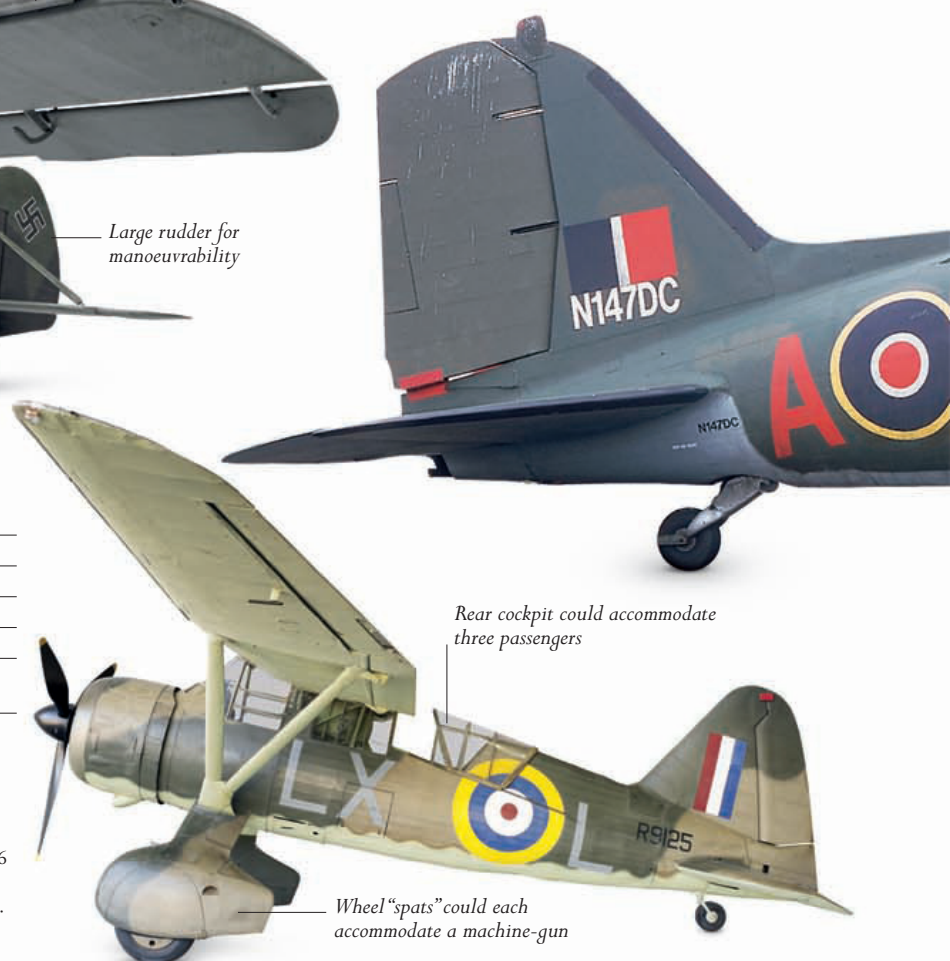
Wingspan 15.25m (50ft)

Length 9.3m (30½ft)

Top speed 340kph (211mph)

Engine 649kW (870hp) Bristol Mercury XX radial

The Lysander was used for World War II army operations, perhaps most famously by the British Royal Air Force's 138 (Special Duties) and 161 Squadrons, which employed it to insert and recover agents in enemy-occupied territory. 1786 were built in total, all of which were withdrawn from service at the war's end.



Rear cockpit could accommodate three passengers

Wheel “spats” could each accommodate a machine-gun